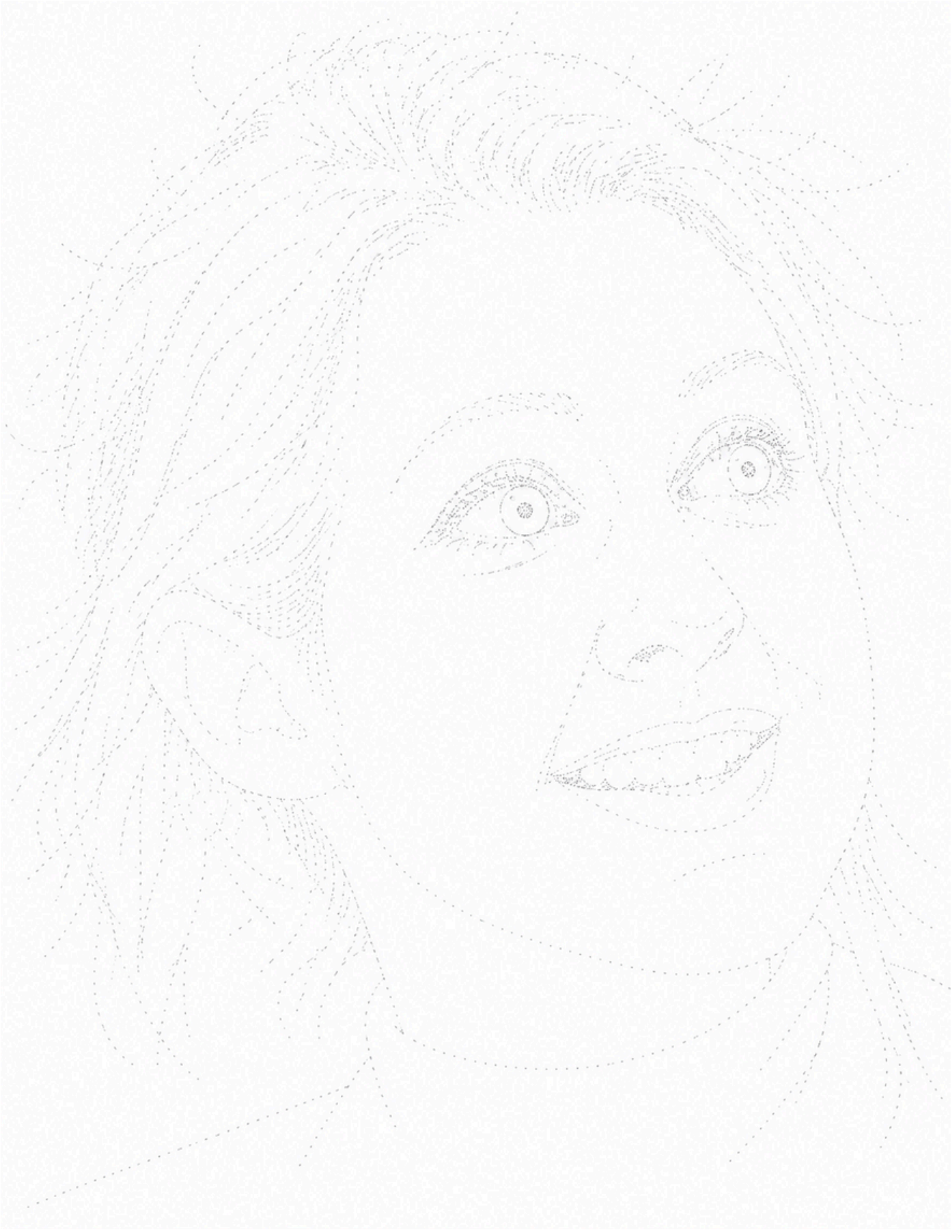
Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



COLORED PENCIL STUDY

Portrait Guide #023

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10-14 hours

Subject A young adult female-presenting person with long dark hair worn down, calm neutral expression, and a black turtleneck top.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

COLOR PALETTE

70% French Grey
PC1074
monochrome value anchor, light pressure structural underpainting

Ginger Root
PC1084
light golden-orange skin tone, lit plane base

Rosy Beige
PC1019
warm undertone wash across forehead zone and neck

Beige Sienna
PC1080
warm midtone shadow, plane transition and nose underside

Sienna Brown
PC945
deep warm core shadow, self-shadow under chin and jaw, nostril depth

Henna
PC1031
red-orange vascular undertone in shadow zones, lip creases

Salmon Pink
PC1001
warm vascular zone on nose, ears, warm mid-face undertone

Seashell Pink
PC1093
light, saturated cheek glow and nose tip highlight

Greyed Lavender
PC1026
chromatic cool note in shadow (not grey), jaw plane transition, upper lip shadow

Lilac
PC956
soft cool undertone in core shadow, adds dimension without flattening

Cobalt Blue Hue
PC133
iris depth, eye shadow, blue bounce from black garment onto jaw

China Blue

PC1100

mid-value iris colour, adds complexity to eye dome

Blue Slate

PC1024

eye shadow and lower iris definition, jaw edge softness

Cream

PC914

sclera base (never pure white), burnish pencil, specular highlight base

Dark Umber

PC947

warm core dark in hair, nostril shadow, loose strand silhouette

90% French Grey

PC1076

cool dark core in hair mass, adds depth without black flatness

Sepia

PC948

warm mid-tone in hair, softens the transition between light and dark

Black

PC935

black turtle neck garment, deepest shadow in hair and eyes

Espresso

PC1099

garment depth and shadow, upper lash line focal accent

30% French Grey

PC1070

background anchor and fade, keeps surround recessive

VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Frontal-left key light at a medium-high angle, creating a smooth transition from lit to shadow side; shadows are soft and rounded, indicating diffuse key light rather than hard directional.

HIGHLIGHT

Cheekbone top, nose tip, upper lip centre; forehead light plane.

LIGHT AREA

Frontal planes—front of forehead, front of cheeks, centre of chin; lit side of nose and bridge.

MIDTONE

Transition zones at temple, side of nose, lower cheek where the form turns; neck catches reduced key light and reads mid-value throughout.

SHADOW

Side of face below the cheekbone turn, jaw side, ear, far side of nose; soft shadow under the nose wing and into the upper lip shadow.

CAST SHADOW

Subtle self-shadow under the jaw into the neck; soft cast on the side of the neck from the jaw overhang.

Edge quality notes

Lit-to-shadow terminator at the cheekbone is the sharpest edge; all other edges soften gradually (temple into hair, jaw into neck, lower face into garment). One silhouette edge is deliberately lost into the background to prevent the head cutting out like a decal.

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01

Step 1: Plane Map and Value Structure (Monochrome)

Full face from hairline to jawline, establishing the five-value range and plane structure

Light pressure directional strokes following form (downward on the forehead, around the side of the head), leaving tooth visibly open

Light pressure

- Value carries form; establish the full range (highlight as paper white, midtone, core shadow, reflected light, cast shadow) at light pressure only to preserve tooth for the glazes still to come.
- Lay down the plane structure using 70% French Grey at minimal pressure: frontal planes (forehead, front cheek, chin front) lightest, side planes (temple, jaw side) mid-value darkening at the terminator, under-planes (brow shelf, lower jaw) subtle shadow.
- Place the core shadow at the cheekbone turn where the form rounds away from light; set a crisp value edge here—this terminator is the structural linchpin of the head.
- Map the self-shadow under the chin in deeper grey, anchoring the head to the neck; keep this warm-toned in intent even though the underpainting is cool-grey.
- Hold the highlights as paper white and negative space; do not fill them—negative highlights read brighter than painted ones because of the paper's actual whiteness beneath.
- Check that the whole face reads three distinct values distinctly (light, mid, dark) before moving forward; if any plane reads ambiguous, deepen its shadow edge.

COLORS PC1074 70% French Grey

↔ If the grey feels too cool, substitute PC1070 30% French Grey (warmer) at the same pressure, or use two pencils—one cool, one warm—side by side to build a warm-neutral undertone instead of a pure cool.

STOP WHEN

The face reads clearly in three-value structure and the core shadow edge at the cheekbone is crisp and set · the pencil slides without friction and does not catch or drag

✦ *The core shadow's POSITION is more important than its depth at this stage; set that line first at the cheekbone turn, then deepen into it in later passes. A misplaced shadow in the wrong plane cannot be fixed by darkening.*

02

Step 2: Undertone and Three-Zone Temperature Map

Full face, establishing three distinct colour zones: forehead (golden-yellow), mid-face (red-pink), jaw/chin (cool-violet)

Circular strokes across the whole zone, feathering edges where zones meet; pressure varies to keep transitions soft

Light pressure

- The three zones have different vascular density and bone proximity; naming them now as colour locks the head's temperature signature so it reads as one person, not three separate mask pieces glued together.
- Glaze the forehead zone (brow ridge and front forehead) in warm golden (PC1084 Ginger Root) at very light pressure; this zone is lit and reads yellowish because bone lies close to the surface.
- Feather the mid-face zone (cheeks, nose sides, upper lip area) in warm salmon-pink (PC1001 Salmon Pink) also at very light pressure; this is the vascular-rich zone and reads warmer and more saturated than the skull-close forehead.
- Bring the jaw and chin zone in a subtle, cool undertone (PC1026 Greyed Lavender at minimal pressure) to establish the denser-tissue, cooler signature before any shaping begins.
- Feather all three zones so their boundaries blend softly into one another while remaining distinguishable as temperature shifts; overlap the colours so the transitions are gradual, not hard stripes.
- Do not fill or over-work; the goal is a transparent undertone glaze that names the zone and temperature, not a local-colour commitment—tooth must remain visibly open.

COLORS PC1084 Ginger Root · PC1001 Salmon Pink · PC1026 Greyed Lavender

↔ If the jaw reads too grey (ashy), add a hair of PC1019 Rosy Beige to warm it; if the mid-face feels flat, raise PC1001 Salmon Pink to medium pressure for one additional layer.

STOP WHEN

The three zones read as distinct temperature shifts (golden forehead, pink mid-face, cool jaw) and the face has a unified warm-cool envelope · pencil leaves visible gaps and tooth shows through every pass

✦ *Do NOT blend this pass into invisibility—the zones need to stay visible as structure under later glazes, or the head will lose its three-dimensional colour story and read as a flat face painted one colour.*

03 Step 3: Colour Build on Frontal and Side Planes (Chroma and Turning Edge)

Lit cheek, side plane transition, temple, jaw edge, nose lit plane—emphasis on where the form TURNS from frontal to side

Circular strokes with optical mixing (layering thin, distinct colours that blend on the paper); glaze order—warm base, sienna, then cool edge, then warm accent—is crucial; directional strokes follow the plane's angle

Light to Medium pressure

- Chroma (saturation) peaks at the turning edge just before the terminator and drops both toward the highlight and into the deepest core shadow; this step teaches the plane change through colour, not just value.
- On the lit cheek: layer warm golden-orange (PC1084 Ginger Root) in circular strokes at medium-light pressure, optically mixing it with the existing undertone glaze; this is the warmest, most saturated note on the face.
- Deepen the lit cheek with warm sienna (PC1080 Beige Sienna) at light-medium pressure; keep pressure light enough that both colours show and mix optically on the paper instead of muddying.
- At the plane change (cheekbone turn): glaze cool lavender (PC1026 Greyed Lavender) very thinly at the edge where the plane rotates away; this cool is a NOTE inside the warm envelope, not the whole tone of the plane.
- On the side plane (temple, jaw side): use mid-value warm brown (PC941 Light Umber) at medium pressure to hold it noticeably darker than the frontal plane; the side plane is the form's backbone and reads three-dimensional BECAUSE it is darker.
- Move the lit side of the nose into warm peachy tones (PC1001 Salmon Pink over the forehead gold) to read the nose as distinct from the brow while keeping the warmth unified.

COLORS PC1084 Ginger Root · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC1026 Greyed Lavender · PC941 Light Umber · PC1001 Salmon Pink

↔ If the core shadow reads too purple-blue, use PC956 Lilac instead of PC1026 (more red undertone and warmer); if the side plane feels flat, add a touch of deep sienna (PC945 Sienna Brown) at the very shadow edge to enrich it.

STOP WHEN

The plane structure is visible through colour (lit plane lighter and more saturated, side plane darker and warmer, core shadow edge crisp) and chroma feels most alive at the plane turn · pencil drags slightly but does not catch or skip, and tooth is still partially visible between strokes

✦ *The plane change from frontal to side IS the three-dimensional form; do not smooth it; keep a value edge AND a temperature edge there even in the final pass. A face*

> *where all planes are one temperature everywhere reads like a mask.*

04 Step 4: Eyes (Iris Layers, Sclera, Lash Line, Specular Highlight)

Both eyes: pupil, iris (full dome), sclera (white), upper and lower lids, upper lash line as the darkest focal accent

Radial strokes for iris (outward from pupil centre), directional strokes for lid planes, one sharp stroke for upper lash line only, gentle feathering for lower lash

Light to Medium for iris; Medium for lash line; Light for lower lash pressure

- Eyes anchor the portrait's life and depth comes from layering the iris with multiple hues (radial outward from the pupil) and reserving TRUE white for ONE specular highlight only; the sclera is never pure white but a warm or cool off-white that sits BEHIND the iris dome.
- Block the pupil and upper-lid cast shadow first in deep cobalt (PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue) at medium pressure; the upper eyelid shadow is the darkest dark in the eye and sets the depth that allows highlights to read bright later.
- Lay down the sclera (white of the eye) in warm cream (PC914 Cream) at light-medium pressure; cream reads warmer and sits closer to the viewer than pure white, so the iris dome sits IN FRONT of it, not embedded.
- Build the iris in radial strokes outward from the pupil in concentric rings: start with mid-value blue (PC1100 China Blue) at the middle ring, then layer deeper cobalt at the outer edge to suggest the iris dome's curve and the shadow on the iris's lower half.
- Add blue-grey (PC1024 Blue Slate) to the shadow side (lower iris) and to a thin ring at the sclera-iris boundary to anchor the eye downward and suggest the globe's volume.
- Reserve a SINGLE sharp specular highlight at the top-inner edge of the iris or just touching the top of the iris on the sclera; use white paper or a sharp touch of cream (PC914); do not scatter highlights around the iris, which flattens the dome.
- Set the upper lash line as the darkest dark, crisp and sure, in deep blue or dark umber (PC133 or PC1099); the lower lash line softens and lifts away to avoid a mirrored, doll-like hardness.

COLORS PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue · PC914 Cream · PC1100 China Blue · PC1024 Blue Slate · PC1099 Espresso · PC938 White

↔ If the sclera reads too cold, use PC1085 Peach Beige instead of Cream; if the iris feels flat after layering, add a thin ring of PC1026 Greyed Lavender at the outer iris edge to suggest the rim's shadow before any burnishing.

STOP WHEN

The iris shows two or three distinct blue hues visible (light, mid, dark) and the pupil is a true black · light reflects in ONE sharp point only and does not scatter · the upper

lash line is crisp and the lower lash line is soft · sclera reads as a warm off-white, not pure white

✦ *Translucency in the eye comes from layering DISTINCT hues (not one 'eye color' pencil) so the iris reads multidimensional, and from a specular highlight that MOVES and shifts as the viewer's eye travels—a static white fill reads glassy. The eye that reads transparent has a bright spot that lives somewhere, not everywhere.*

05 Step 5: Nose and Ears (Subsurface Scattering and Vascular Glow)

Nose (tip, wings, underside, nostrils), ears (full structure, concha, lobe), plus the surrounding soft tissue zones where light penetrates thin skin

Directional strokes downward for the nose (following its axis) and around the ear form; varied pressure so highlight areas stay light and shadows deepen gradually

Medium, varying light in highlight zones (nose tip, ear lobe) pressure

- Subsurface scattering—light enters translucent skin and bounces inside—makes thin vascular areas glow warm red-pink even in shadow; noses and ears read ALIVE when this glow is exaggerated, making skin read as skin rather than wax.
- Glaze the nose tip and the soft zone around the nostrils in warm salmon-pink (PC1001 Salmon Pink) at medium pressure; this zone catches both the key light AND internal warmth and should read WARMER and LIGHTER than the surrounding cheek, even if it dips slightly into shadow.
- Layer a lighter, brighter peach (PC1093 Seashell Pink) over the very top of the nose tip dome; this is the secondary highlight after the eye and reads as the nose's peak.
- Darken the nostril shadows with deep warm brown (PC947 Dark Umber) at medium pressure; KEEP the shadow warm—do not cool it with blue or grey, which reads as the absence of light rather than form shadow.
- Bring warm mid-tone (PC941 Light Umber or PC1080 Beige Sienna) across the underside of the nose (ala, septum shadow, base) to hold the structure and warmth.
- For the ears: establish the ear structure in warm tan (PC1080 Beige Sienna) at light-medium pressure; add deeper warm shadow (PC945 Sienna Brown) in the concha and behind the ear; reserve the ear lobe as a highlight.
- Ears are always slightly warmer and more saturated than the adjacent cheek; do not match them to the face tone—they should read as if lit from within.

COLORS PC1001 Salmon Pink · PC1093 Seashell Pink · PC947 Dark Umber · PC941 Light Umber · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC945 Sienna Brown

↔ If nostril shadows read too brown and lose the red warmth, use PC1031 Henna instead (more red-orange); if ears feel separate from the face, tint them with the same salmon pink (PC1001) used on the nose to integrate them.

STOP WHEN

The nose tip glows visibly warmer and lighter than its surrounding shadow and reads like living tissue, not a pencil mark · ears sit forward (highlight visible) and back (shadow defined) with visible form · pressure varies so the nose tip feels like it's catching light

> ✦ *The nose and ears are the PROOF that subsurface scattering is real in colored pencil—exaggerate them slightly and the whole face reads more alive because the artist has acknowledged that skin is translucent. Skip them and even a perfect face goes plastic.*

06 Step 6: Lips and Mouth Structure (Upper Lip Cool, Lower Lip Warm)

Upper lip, lower lip, mouth opening (if visible), lip line integration with the face

Soft feathering at the lip line; circular strokes for the lip color; very sharp, light pressure for creases

Light to Medium; very Light for creases pressure

- The mouth is the second focal accent after the eyes and must stay COOL on top (upper lip darker, shadowed by the skull overhang) and WARM on the bottom (lower lip lighter, wetter, more saturated); the lip line is soft and integrated, never a hard outline.
- Establish the upper lip in a cool, dark tone (PC1026 Greyed Lavender or PC956 Lilac) at light-medium pressure; the upper lip is in structural shadow and reads cooler and darker than the lower lip.
- Glaze the lower lip in warm salmon-pink (PC1001 Salmon Pink) at medium pressure; this is the wettest, warmest, most saturated area of the mouth and reads distinctly lighter than the upper lip.
- Soften the lip line by feathering the edges gently with a tortillon or blending pencil so the lips integrate with the face; a hard outline reads like makeup, not skin.
- If the mouth opening is visible, keep it deep and warm (PC947 Dark Umber or PC1078 Black Cherry) to suggest the mouth interior; avoid pure black, which reads flat and cuts the form.
- Add fine vertical creases on the upper lip and horizontal lines on the lower lip using a sharp pencil (PC947 Dark Umber or PC1031 Henna) at VERY light pressure; these details come last and must stay delicate—overwork here makes the mouth read dry and old.

COLORS PC1026 Greyed Lavender · PC956 Lilac · PC1001 Salmon Pink · PC947 Dark Umber · PC1078 Black Cherry · PC1031 Henna

↔ If the upper lip reads too purple, use PC1025 Periwinkle instead (less saturation); if the mouth feels too bold overall, tone it with a thin layer of neutral warm (PC1019 Rosy Beige) at light pressure.

STOP WHEN

The lower lip reads visibly lighter and warmer than the upper lip · mouth edges blend into the face without a hard outline · creases are visible but do not look carved or dry

✦ *A mouth is NEVER the most saturated note on a face—it reads as part of the person, not a lipstick advertisement. Keep the cheek more vibrant than the mouth; keep the eye more focused than the mouth. The mouth should be the last thing the eye lands on, not the first.*

07

Step 7: Jaw, Chin, and Shaved-Plane Cool (No Facial Hair Pathway)

Jaw edge, chin front, jaw-to-neck transition; full jaw plane because there is no facial hair to break it up

Directional strokes following the jaw's angle (backward and downward); keep the chin stroke centred and light; feather the jaw edge to avoid a hard line

Light to Medium pressure

- The jaw and chin are dense bone and muscle, cooler in temperature than the forehead; because there is NO facial hair to obscure this plane, the coolness and value shift are the sole indicators of structure here.
- Map the jaw edge in subtle cool (PC1026 Greyed Lavender at light pressure) to set the plane change from cheek to jaw; keep this barely visible—a jaw that reads as a hard purple line reads as makeup, not form.
- Deepen the jaw edge where it turns back toward the ear and neck with mid-value cool (PC1024 Blue Slate) at medium pressure; this edge is softer than the cheekbone terminator but still present and helps read the jaw's angle.
- Glaze the chin front in the same cool-lavender tone, keeping it lighter than the jaw edge so the chin reads as catching some frontal light and sitting forward in space.
- Bring a touch of warm sienna (PC1080 Beige Sienna) into the very centre of the chin to warm it and suggest the front-facing light there; the chin should not read as a cold, separate piece.
- Set a crisp, warm self-shadow just under the chin (where it meets the neck) in deep warm brown (PC945 Sienna Brown) at medium pressure; this shadow grounds the head to the neck below and reads as form shadow, not a bruise.

COLORS PC1026 Greyed Lavender · PC1024 Blue Slate · PC1080 Beige Sienna · PC945 Sienna Brown

↔ If the jaw reads too grey and lifeless, warm it with PC1019 Rosy Beige or PC1080 Beige Sienna layered lightly; if the self-shadow under the chin feels too dark, use PC1080 Beige Sienna instead of deep brown.

STOP WHEN

The jaw reads as a distinct plane (cooler than cheek, darker than chin front) with a soft edge · the self-shadow under the chin is crisp and warm · no hard outline appears on the jaw edge

✦ *On a hairless, smooth jaw, COOL colour and VALUE hierarchy alone carry the structure—there is no texture or grain to help. Keep the cool consistent but subtle (a note, not the whole tone), and keep the edge hierarchy crisp to read the form.*

08 Step 8: Neck, Jaw Shadow, and Skin-to-Garment Transition

Neck (front, sides, back), under-jaw self-shadow, colour bounce from the black garment onto the neck and lower jaw

Directional strokes downward (following the neck's axis) and around the sides; soft feathering at the garment edge; pressure varies so the front of the neck stays light

Light to Medium; Light for the garment bounce pressure

- The neck is a cylinder that turns away on all sides and catches little of the key light, so it reads mid-value and warm with a self-shadow everywhere it meets the jaw above; the black garment bounces its hue upward, cooling the shadow side and integrating the head to the body.
- Establish the lit front of the neck in warm beige (PC1019 Rosy Beige or PC1084 Ginger Root) at light-medium pressure, lighter than the face because the neck is smoother and less wrinkled.
- Bring the core face tones (sienna, warm brown) down into the side and back of the neck to hold depth and warmth; the neck is not a separate colour from the face, just a continuous turning form.
- Set a defined self-shadow under the jaw and along the side of the neck in deep warm brown (PC945 Sienna Brown or PC947 Dark Umber) at medium pressure; this grounds the head and reads as form shadow.
- Glaze the shadow side of the neck (and underside of the jaw) with a cool blue-grey (PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue or PC1026 Greyed Lavender) at light pressure to introduce the black garment's colour bounce; this is a subtle cool, not a heavy cast.
- Taper the neck-to-garment edge softly so the skin colour lifts away into black gradually; no hard line should appear where skin ends and fabric begins.

COLORS PC1019 Rosy Beige · PC1084 Ginger Root · PC945 Sienna Brown · PC947 Dark Umber · PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue · PC1026 Greyed Lavender

↔ If the neck-to-jaw transition feels abrupt, use more feathering with a blending pencil; if the garment bounce reads too strong (too blue), reduce it to a whisper of PC1026 at very light pressure.

STOP WHEN

The neck reads as a form between jaw and garment, not a flat strip · the self-shadow under the jaw is crisp while the garment-bounce coolness is subtle · the transition reads integrated

> ✦ *The neck is the HINGE between face and garment; if it reads stiff or separate, the head floats; if it's soft and integrated, the whole figure anchors. Invest time in the transition.*

09 Step 9: Surround in One Gestural Pass—Hair, Garment, Background

Hair (crown, sides, back, loose strand), black turtle neck (full garment to shoulders), background

Directional strokes for hair (down the length), even fill for garment, feathering from dark to light for background (anchor strong, fade weak), one stroke deliberately softened and lost

Light to Medium for hair; Medium for garment; Light to feather background pressure

- The surround is gestural by design—economical, directional, tooth open on purpose—because the artist's attention is the face; a fully rendered background competes with the head and kills the portrait. ANCHOR at the face, then FADE outward, with ONE deliberately lost silhouette edge so the head does not cut out like a decal.
- HAIR: Begin at the hairline where hair meets the forehead in warm dark brown (PC947 Dark Umber) at medium pressure, following the hair's grown direction (downward); anchor the dark HERE so the hair reads as sitting behind the face.
- Layer the hair's mid-value in a cooler dark (PC1076 90% French Grey) in long directional strokes down the hair's length; this is the core dark that suggests volume without filling every strand. OPEN TOOTH SHOWS ON PURPOSE—this is a choice, not an unfinished edge.
- Flick a few loose strands at the silhouette (including the loose strand noted in the artist brief) in sharp pencil (PC947 Dark Umber) at light pressure; ONLY the silhouette gets strand detail; the interior mass stays gestural.
- GARMENT: Fill the black turtle neck in pure black (PC935 Black) at light-medium pressure, keeping coverage even and smooth. Add depth at the neckline and shoulder in darker black (PC1099 Espresso) at medium pressure.
- Introduce a BLUE BOUNCE from the black onto the lower jaw and neck edge in cobalt (PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue) at light pressure; this subtle blue shows the garment's reflective influence and integrates the head into the body.
- BACKGROUND: Use a neutral mid-grey (PC1070 30% French Grey) ONLY where it meets the head—darker behind the lit side of the face to make the head read forward, lighter behind the shadow side to push the shadow side forward. Fade outward to paper white with diminishing strokes, never a hard halo.
- DELIBERATELY LOSE ONE SILHOUETTE EDGE (usually the upper side of the head into the background) so the head does not cut out entirely; keep at least one area where hair and background blur together.

COLORS PC947 Dark Umber · PC1076 90% French Grey · PC935 Black · PC1099 Espresso · PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue · PC1070 30% French Grey

↔ Hair too light, use PC935 Black for the mid-value anchor instead; background too dark or close, reduce pressure and stop the fade sooner.

STOP WHEN

Hair anchors dark at the head and fades to open strokes at the edges; garment sits flat and dark with depth at the neckline; background is darker behind light skin and lighter behind shadow, fading to white; ONE edge is visibly lost · no hard halo frames the head all the way around

✦ *Gesture does NOT mean blur or skip—it means INTENTION. The dark at the hairline is a deliberate anchor, not an accident, and the fade is a conscious choice that reads as 'I know the surround is not the focal point.' That knowledge makes the face read LOUDER.*

10

Step 10: Edge Hierarchy, Burnish Face, Re-Punch Darks, Peak Highlights

Entire face (burnish pass only), darkest accents (upper lash line, core shadows, nostril shadows), specular highlights (eye, nose tip, cheekbone peak)

Circular burnishing passes (multiple), then sharp directional re-punching, then soft feathering to lose edges; wax-bloom wipe with soft cloth

Heavy (burnish); Heavy (re-punch darks); Light (soften edges) pressure

- Burnishing closes the tooth and creates a smooth, luminous finish (colored pencil's 'painting' moment), but wax blooms upward and LIGHTENS values—re-punching the darks is REQUIRED, not optional. The hardest edge (upper lash line) is the single focal accent; all other edges soften and some are lost outward. Peak highlights have a hard value JUMP beside them so light reads true.
- Burnish the ENTIRE FACE (not the surround) with a light pencil (PC914 Cream or PC938 White) at heavy pressure, using circular strokes and multiple passes until NO white flecks (tooth) show anywhere. This seals all layers and creates the luminous skin finish.
- IMMEDIATELY RE-PUNCH the deepest darks: core shadow under the cheekbone, nostril shadows, upper lash line, eye pupil, in their original pencils (PC945, PC947, PC1024, PC133) at heavy pressure; burnishing lifts these, so replacing them is MANDATORY.
- Set ONE crisp focal edge—the UPPER LASH LINE—in the darkest pencil available (PC1099 Espresso or PC935 Black) with a sharp, sure stroke; this edge is the portrait's sharpest focus and must be shorter than the lower lash line, which softens and lifts away.
- Establish peak highlights: on the cheekbone's highest point, the eye's specular highlight (one sharp point), and the nose tip—use a combination of the surrounding tone VERY LIGHT + a slightly DEEPER half-tone beside it to make the peak read as a value JUMP, not just a white fill. Simultaneous contrast wins the highlight.
- Soften and deliberately LOSE edges outward: the jaw edge blurs into the neck, the temple dissolves into the hair, the shadow side of the face fades into the background—keep hard edges ONLY at focal accents (lash line, nostril definition).
- Wipe away any wax bloom with a soft cloth and re-check the final values; the deepest darks should read distinctly darker than the midtones and the highlights should have a crisp jump.

COLORS

- PC914 Cream
- PC938 White
- PC945 Sienna Brown
- PC947 Dark Umber
- PC1024 Blue Slate
- PC133 Cobalt Blue Hue
- PC1099 Espresso
- PC935 Black

↔ If burnishing reads too shiny or plastic, reduce to one pass and soften the finish with very light pressure; if re-punched darks are too black and hard, use PC947 Dark Umber instead for a warm depth.

STOP WHEN

Whole face reads smooth and luminous with NO visible tooth and all white flecks gone · deepest darks are visibly darker than the surrounding tone · edges are crisp ONLY at the focal accent (upper lash line) and soft everywhere else · hand is steady and the pencil glides without friction

✦ *Burnishing LIGHTENS values—embrace it and darken intentionally after. This is not a flaw, it is the technique. The peak highlight reads BRIGHT not because it is white, but because the tone BESIDE it is DARKER—that simultaneous contrast makes the eye read depth and luminosity instead of a flat white mark. The sharpest edge in the whole face should be the upper lash line; every other edge softens outward.*

WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.